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I have said that relationships within the band are built on the model of kinship. This obviously imposes some limitation on the types of relationship that are permitted between various individuals (e.g., joking versus respect), and some relationships are highly restrictive of the nature of interaction (e.g., between one woman and the husband of another). Density is limited, therefore, insofar as variety is restricted, and as channels of communication, some of the more restrictive relationships have rather small capacity. However, where first-order (i.e., direct) contact is attenuated, the structure is such that there is ample "channel capacity" in second-order contact. (Although I must be circumspect in my communicative behavior toward another man's wife, I am allowed considerable freedom when talking to her husband.) The properties of the network, then, are such that those involved can perceive with reasonable commonality the actions that are performed in the band, the circumstances surrounding the actions, and the nuances of meaning that are attributed to both. It follows, of course, that although the use of the kinship system as an organizational framework does impose some restrictions on information flow, it also enhances the informational value of interaction by providing a matrix of meaning for a substantial proportion of transactions in the prescriptions and definitions that are part of kinship. In Ashby's terms, the amount of requisite variety is reduced by the use of the kinship system, correspondingly lessening the rate of flow of information required to coordinate the behavior of the co-resident band members.

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I cannot satisfactorily explain the upper limit of about 100 but suggest that this is the largest number of people who can sustain first- and second-order contact in normal social intercourse. In other words, a larger number of people would either have to resort to third order of contact and higher or slow down or otherwise attenuate their interaction with one another. I had thought that the idea could [303](#) be explored in a fairly straightforward computer

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simulation, but I conclude that the rates of generation and communication of information in the community must be critical. To perceive and measure these, an observer would need the kind of sensitivity I referred to in the Preface and should also have detailed knowledge of the backgrounds of all members of the band. A simulation would have some heuristic value but, lacking this intimate quantification, would not be appreciably less vague than is the first sentence of this paragraph.

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